TERRAFORM STATE MANAGEMENT

The Terraform mistake that can break your infrastructure team

State is Terraform's memory of what exists. Lose it, corrupt it or leak it, and every plan becomes a guess.

✗ Risky

- **Local state** on one laptop
- **State committed to Git**, secrets included
- **No locking:** two applies at once
- **One giant state** for everything

✓ Safe

- **Remote backend:** S3 / Azure Blob / GCS
- **Locking** on every plan and apply
- **Encrypted, versioned,** least-privilege access
- **Split state** by env and component

CHANGE STATE SAFELY

01 Plan in CI, never on a laptop

02 Lock acquired automatically

03 Review the plan, then apply

04 Refactor with moved / import blocks

Remember: state can hold secrets in plain text. Treat the state bucket like a password vault.

01 · THE HOOK

The Terraform mistake that breaks teams is rarely bad HCL

It's state.

Someone runs apply from a laptop with stale local state. Two pipelines apply at the same time. A state file with database passwords gets committed to Git.

Every one of these is preventable, and every one is painful to clean up.

02 · THE PROBLEM

What state actually is

State is Terraform's record of **which real resources belong to which configuration**: their IDs, attributes and dependencies.

- → **Lost state:** Terraform no longer knows what it manages, and plans try to create everything again
- → **Concurrent applies:** two writers at once risk corrupted state
- → **Leaked state:** state can contain sensitive values **in plain text**
- → **One giant state:** slow plans, and every change risks everything

03 · THE ARCHITECTURE

A safe remote-state flow

1 · CI runner (not a laptop)

Short-lived cloud credentials via OIDC; plan and apply run in the pipeline

2 · Lock acquired

A second run waits or fails instead of writing over the first

3 · Read state → plan → reviewed apply

The plan output is reviewed before apply, just like a code review

4 · New state version written

Encrypted bucket with versioning on, so every previous version is recoverable

Access: least privilege

Only the pipeline role writes. Very few humans can read.

Remote backends in all three clouds

```hcl
# AWS: S3 with native locking (Terraform 1.10+)
terraform {
  backend "s3" {
    bucket       = "acme-tfstate-prod"
    key          = "network/terraform.tfstate"
    region       = "us-east-1"
    encrypt      = true
    use_lockfile = true
  }
}
# Azure: locking via blob leases
terraform {
  backend "azurerm" {
    resource_group_name  = "rg-tfstate"
    storage_account_name = "acmetfstateprod"
    container_name       = "tfstate"
    key                  = "network.tfstate"
  }
}
# GCP: locking supported by the gcs backend
terraform {
  backend "gcs" {
    bucket = "acme-tfstate-prod"
    prefix = "network"
  }
}
```

Change and recover state safely

```
# Rename without destroy/recreate (TF 1.1+)
moved {
  from = aws_instance.web
  to   = aws_instance.app
}
# Adopt an existing resource (TF 1.5+)
import {
  to = aws_s3_bucket.logs
  id = "acme-logs"
}
```

```
# Detect drift without changing anything
terraform plan -refresh-only
# Last resort, only if the lock is truly stale
terraform force-unlock LOCK_ID
```

> **Recovery:** with bucket versioning on, a bad write is fixed by restoring the previous state version.

How small should each state be?

Split state

✓ Small blast radius
✓ Fast plans
✓ Clear ownership
✗ Dependencies between states need managing

One big state

✓ Simple references
✗ Slow plans
✗ Every change risks everything
✗ Broad access to sensitive data

Watch out: the terraform_remote_state data source needs read access to another config's whole state. Consider publishing just the outputs you need to a parameter store instead.

06 · THE TAKEAWAY

Terraform state checklist

- ☐ Remote backend for every environment, no local state
- ☐ State files never committed to Git (.gitignore them)
- ☐ Locking on for every plan and apply
- ☐ Encryption at rest and bucket versioning on
- ☐ Write access only for the pipeline role
- ☐ State split by environment and component
- ☐ Refactors done with moved / import blocks
- ☐ Restore procedure written down and tested

07 · YOUR TURN

How does your team protect Terraform state from accidental changes?

Share your safeguards in the comments.

Follow Deji Ajishe

for the rest of this 30-part multi-cloud DevOps series

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linkedin.com/in/deji-ajishe-64a35722a